

LIVING HIS DREAM AT THE ZENITH OF SPORT

Harmeet Desai's maiden appearance in the Olympics is a **testament to his hard work** and dedicated family support.

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Harmeet Desai is neither a party animal nor particularly inclined towards festivals or family functions. However, when the Indian table tennis contingent makes its debut at the Paris Olympics this month, it will be an occasion the 30-year-old from Surat will cherish. Not only will he fulfill his decade-old dream of becoming an Olympian, but he will also compete as one of the two men's singles players, alongside veteran Sharath Kamal.

It has been a long wait, but it's worth it. "It means a lot. It's almost 24-25 years of hard work. I think it's every sportsperson's dream to represent their country in the Olympics. I am really excited and looking forward to playing my first Olympics," Harmeet says in his trademark soft-spoken manner.

We are seated at the Sports Authority of India's campus in Bengaluru, just hours before Harmeet experiences his final sunset in India before officially becoming an Olympian. After participating in three preparatory tournaments and undergoing personal

training in Germany, he will join his teammates in Paris. This schedule means he won't reunite with his family — parents Rajul and Archana, wife Krittwika, and elder brother Hraday — until August.

As he narrates his story, you can sense him reminiscing about his days as a five-and-a-half-year-old, hooked on three racquet sports — tennis, badminton, and table tennis. To play tennis, he had to venture out of his home in Surat. But for table tennis, he could play at home, thanks to his father Rajul, a university-level paddler, who had bought a table for home use.

Around four months after he was introduced to the game, Rajul realised that his son had ball sense — the innate quality required to be a paddler. He then asked Harmeet to choose one of the three racquet

